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BOOK REVIEW

Lotze's Philosophy of Psychology: Reconceiving the Soul, by Mark Textor, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2026, pp. 234 $105.00 (hardcover), ISBN 9780192869531

William James famously asserted that: 'Everyone knows what attention is. It is the taking possession by the mind, in clear and vivid form, of one out of what seem several simultaneously possible objects or trains of thought.'[1] This 'selective directedness' is what James names 'focalization' and it begins to dominate in the course of the twentieth century, becoming known as the 'spotlight theory' of attention: attention is thereby configured as a sort of roving gaze, shining a unique light upon singular objects of special interest. Attention is a selective act, narrowly focusing on one specific object. This view thus became foundational for many researchers in contemporary cognitive science.

The volume under consideration here presents readers with a long-ignored alternative. The author, Mark Textor, is a Professor of Philosophy at King's College London, specializing in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century philosophy of mind and psychology, and producing important work in the history of analytic philosophy. It will introduce many to the views of Hermann Lotze (1817–1881), particularly with regard to the philosophy of mind and of psychology. Although almost completely forgotten (until recently), in his day Lotze inspired many.

Lotze was informed by the mathematics and the natural science of his time without capitulating to a naive scientism. He defended what he called the 'soul' and thus stands against those demanding a 'psychology without a soul.' This leads him to develop a rich account of feeling, attention, comparison, as well as both self-consciousness and the unity of consciousness. The contents of Textor's volume are thus neatly divided into two main parts: 'Part I. Feeling and Related Mental Phenomena' and 'Part II. Comparing as the Activity of the Soul.'

Lotze and some contemporary approaches view attention not as a simple mechanism of selection but rather as playing a basic role in structuring the mental 'field.' Textor reconstructs, and defends in part, Lotze's 'Comparison Thesis,' or the now-forgotten, minority view that vests attention in a special synthetic or relating activity of consciousness. Further, Lotze's general approach is, at base, an *affective* picture of self-consciousness, one that firmly places attention (and our mentality generally) into the realm of *feeling*. Lotze's radical alternative is thus that self-consciousness is neither intellectual nor propositional but rooted in feeling, awareness, and interest. What is 'mine' is identified via feeling and not cognition.

Lotze on 'self-consciousness' and on 'comparing' are really just two faces of one and the same project: self-consciousness is scarcely a bare 'given' but rather something accomplished and achieved through the very processes of comparing. Comparing is thus the principal manner in which our own awareness of self comes about.

Furthermore, we must not think of attention as an act of choosing amongst already fully individuated objects: rather, individuation itself is only possible through this same process of comparison, which fundamentally is a 'relating activity' (*beziehende Tätigkeit*). In other words, we require a synthetic operation through which we become aware of relations among the various parts of what we perceive. The 'Comparison Thesis,' where consciousness holds objects 'together' as well as 'apart,' is incompatible with any view committed to

consciousness as a mere succession of separate mental states, where just one item is present before consciousness at any given time.

Lotze had originally argued precisely that this feature of consciousness yields two conclusions: (1) there is a traditional, simple 'soul'; and (2) consciousness possesses an indivisible unity. Lotze's view requires the unity of consciousness for the reason that comparison itself requires such unity. Textor contends that Lotze himself fails to establish the first, but offers a powerful case for the second. Lotze's view was, however, not so much refuted as merely mothballed. Textor himself suggests that 'the idea of a close relation between attention and comparison disappears after 1920 and James's focalization model starts to dominate discussions of attention' (p. 103).

This is a very rich work and has something to offer anyone willing to consider it. Textor proceeds without any regard for the traditional 'scruples' that used to dog most work in the history of philosophy: either one is engaged in an historical endeavour that is completely disconnected from the contemporary scene or one is making an up-to-date and completely relevant contribution to said scene. On Textor's account, the historical work is congruent with a number of different contemporary approaches, as well as offering the possibility of a retrieval that challenges the widespread cultural amnesia of the analytic tradition. There are many different strands that could hence be fruitfully pursued and elaborated.

While of course Kant, Herbart, Brentano, and Stumpf receive significant coverage, an important historical debate also is surveyed here: Bradley's counter-claim that attention can take place without explicit comparative relations, such that attending is fully detachable from any of the consequences of attending, including conceptual clarity and cognitive distinctness. But Textor's Lotze insists that merely isolating an object is cognitively inert without active comparison against some external standard (cf. pp. 103ff). Thus any desire for clarity and distinctness exposes the need for comparison, which is inherently relational.

In high philosophical modernism, all of this went swiftly by the wayside. Those earlier figures which could be assimilated into the new paradigms continued to persist, with some form of relevance, while numerous others merely dropped out of sight entirely. This work stands, alongside others, against the continued dominion of cultural amnesia that assumes intellectual progress has been a constructive process in which nothing of value has been lost or misplaced.

Others may remain sceptical, unimpressed by this or any other attempt to rescue the forgotten past. For many, comparison (or any *awareness-that)* must yield a judgement. Textor's Lotze believes that comparison is not only prior (both genetically and logically) to judgement but even to the formation of general concepts: it is a purely non-conceptual, perceptual awareness of a relation. Other theorists, such as Tye, however, reject the notion that there is any such *experience* of difference, insisting that relational distinction must arise and be clearly relocated within judgement, in the realm of the cognitive itself.[2]

I would have liked it if Textor had fully developed Lotze's view in light of the greater *Logik*, because there a similar notion of relating underwrites both judgement and validity (*Geltung*), but I strongly suspect more work will be forthcoming. As it stands, Textor's book reminds us that there are many things which we do not yet know, although earlier figures may have cleared the first forest paths. Frege's lament remains apposite: 'It is sad and discouraging to observe how discoveries once made are always threatening to be lost again in this way, and how much work promises to have been done in vain, because we fancy ourselves so well off that we need not bother to assimilate its results.'[3]

Notes

1. James, *The Principles of Psychology*.
2. Tye, *Consciousness, Colour, and Content*
3. Frege, *Die Grundlagen der Arithmetik*.

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